iPhone 18 Pro Max

Finally with Pro controls

₹1,79,900



REVIEW IN PROGRESS

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One of the biggest gripes I've had with Apple is how their Pro iPhones never truly felt Pro enough, right out of the box. The hardware was always great to rival more expensive pro cams, but it seemed to lack first-party controls to truly unlock its creative potential. That finally ends with the iPhone 18 Pro series, I'm glad to announce.

And before pointing at ProRAW, ProRes, Apple Log and the alphabet soup of professional video formats Apple has been steadily piling onto the iPhone, hear me out.

Apple had built one of the most sophisticated video cameras you could fit inside a trouser pocket, yet left you handicapped with the in-built Camera app for years. Apple largely wanted you to point, compose and trust Cupertino – or third-party apps. The Pro iPhone's problem was never capability, it was always control, which thankfully the iPhone 18 Pro puts squarely into your hands.

Because "Pro" shouldn't mean the phone is capable of professional things – if I install the right software, attach the right SSD and disappear three levels deep into Settings. A professional tool should give me the option of taking responsibility for the result, and prioritise controls that I want. And then just get out of my way. The iPhone 18 Pro Max finally gets this.

PRO CONTROLS, RIGHT IN THE CAMERA APP

Open Apple's Camera app and there are now proper Pro controls for shutter speed, white balance and aperture, which is one of the most meaningful camera hardware debuting on the iPhone 18 Pro series. You can pull up a histogram to judge exposure rather than relying entirely on how the preview looks. Manual focus has finally arrived too, complete with highlighted in-focus areas, and you can lock the phone to the Ultra Wide, Main or Telephoto camera rather than losing control and allowing every decision to be taken by Apple's computational machinery.

These aren't buried inside some obscure developer mode either. Apple lets you customize which tools sit above the viewfinder, so the controls you actually use can always remain within reach. That may sound like a tiny interface tweak, but it maximises the iPhone 18 Pro / Max's creative appeal to any professional creator.

Then there's the actual aperture on the 48MP main Fusion camera. Open it up when the light disappears. Stop it down when I want greater depth of field across a group or landscape. Slow the shutter deliberately to introduce motion. Set the white balance because I want the photograph warm, not because an algorithm concluded that warm was technically incorrect.

That last sentence gets to the heart of why this matters. Smartphone photography has spent the past decade becoming spectacularly good at preventing mistakes. But creativity often requires being allowed to make the "wrong" decision on purpose for, well, creative effect. That is what Apple appears to have finally acknowledged with the iPhone 18 Pro Max.

BIG PHONE, BIGGER STAMINA

Coming from the iPhone 13 Pro and, more recently, the iPhone 15 Pro, my first reaction to the iPhone 18 Pro Max remains unchanged – it's enormous! At 249g, its 6.9-inch display and 78mm-wide body fundamentally change how I use an iPhone. The upside is that the 18 Pro Max finally earns some of that bulk back. Battery life is superb, easily lasting over a day, with no charge anxiety. That matters more to me than another synthetic benchmark victory.

So does the A20 Pro, although its goodness is less about watching apps open fractionally faster and more about how little the phone seems to care about whatever you throw at it. Apple's six-core CPU, seven-core GPU, dual 16-core Neural Engine and redesigned vapour chamber give it enormous headroom for gaming, photo work and increasingly AI-heavy workloads.

And then there is Siri AI, probably the first version of Siri in years that I have deliberately gone looking for rather than accidentally toggled on. It's more conversational, better at retaining context across requests and more useful when the task involves information already living on the phone. Apple Intelligence also brings handy photo tools such as Reframe and Extend, while improved dictation feels like the sort of quality-of-life upgrade that should